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It's no longer smart to be chic...The new mode is casual, bold, chunky and realistic.

VOGUE, 1936

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1935–36

1935

Italian-born Elsa Schiaparelli opens her first designer Boutique at 21 Place Vendôme, Paris, France.



▲ A pair of nylon stockings

1935

Nylon is invented by Wallace Carothers at DuPont's research facility. It is used as a substitute for silk in many different products.

1937–38

1937

The Spanish designer Cristóbal Balenciaga opens his couture house in Paris. He had had boutiques in Spain since 1918.

1939–40

1939

England and France declare war on Germany in September 1939. Clothes have to be practical. *Vogue* patterns are now for trousers for volunteer drivers. Sweaters become the basis of most looks; skirts are long and full.

1941–42

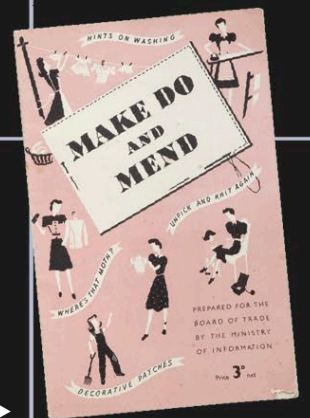


▲ Rosie the Riveter

1943–44

1943

The Zoot Suit riots explode in Los Angeles, California. White sailors and marines take umbrage at young Mexican Americans wearing suits that use large amounts of cloth.



▶ Wartime pamphlet

1945–46

1936

Edward VIII abdicates the throne of England. His American mistress, Mrs Wallis Simpson, is dressed by Mainbocher for their wedding.



◀ Mrs Wallis Simpson's wedding dress

1936

As more women take on paid employment, daytime looks are tailored and angular, with square epauletted shoulders, frogging, plumed hats, low heels, and gauntlet gloves.



▲ *Gone with the Wind*

1939

Gone With The Wind is released, picking up brilliantly on the air of insecurity and emphasizing a feminine, romantic note in fashion that would not be seen again until Dior's New Look in 1947.

1940

Ties become wider, with bolder patterns that range from Art Deco designs to tropical themes.

◀ Hand-painted tie



1942

Rosie the Riveter is the star of a song that praises the American women working in factories. Her much-admired practical image has her dressed in a blue overall, hair concealed underneath a red spotted scarf.

1944

Rationing becomes severe, and where economies in designs can be made, they are. Fabrics are cheap and cuts are sparing.

1944

A highly visible, military presence provides inspiration for designers during wartime. Civilian fashion seeks to emulate the uniform of servicemen and women.

▼ American GIs in Paris, 1944



1946

The first Paris collections after the war foreshadow Dior's New Look of 1947.



▲ Slim-cut herringbone suit